HOW 2012 Planning guide.

Peter Squires, 20th March 2012

Preliminaries:

Find land. Set date to get the best moon.

Find landowners. Grant Hunter, Penny Wright, Dave Laurie, and Allister Metherall are good.

Get permission.

Make map. Bill Kennedy, Dave Laurie

Appoint a land-owner contact team.

Prepare advertising, and entry forms.

Make a timetable for the steps to follow.

PLANNING.

1. Step 1. Each person or team to plan checkpoint locations on map, after HH site determined. Checkpoints to have a preliminary description.
2. Step 2. Meeting to compare courses, discuss ideas, and create a single course plan. Modify CP description list.
3. Step 3. Site visit to place semi-permanent markers at checkpoint locations. Modify locations as required, and take GPS readings at every site. Update CP descriptions.
4. Step 4. Revise map based on information from site visit. Make checkpoint description list. Allocate values to each checkpoint, and add these to the description.
5. Step 5. Vetting trip. Re-visit course with modified map and cross-check other people's checkpoints. Where query arises, get third opinion on the day, or someone else to make another visit.
6. Step 6. Finalise map and get printed. (Bill, Dave.)
7. Step 7. Put check-points out a week or two before event. Prepare registration packs.
8. Step 8. Day before event. Prepare site. Place water drops. Registration packs.
9. Step 9. Run the event.
10. Step 10. Bring in checkpoints and clear site.

OTHER TASKS. Catering, power supply, heating, toilets, prizes and trophies, parking and signage, safety plan, traffic management and safety.

Some details and hints:

Step 1. Planning a course. This is heaps of fun and is also challenging.

From the website:

On a small but hilly map, you may want these about 1 km apart. In flatter or easy country, make them further apart. The locations of checkpoints should be a feature shown on the map, such as a gully, spur, saddle, building etc; or a feature not shown but which can be located from information which is on the map. Convention states that features which ARE on the map are referred to as "THE saddle, THE spur" etc. whereas features not on the map are referred to as "A spur, A gully, A watercourse junction" etc. You should try to locate the checkpoints so that there is no obvious best-route to visit them or travel between them. You want the competitors to make different decisions about their courses. This idea can be enhanced by the point-values you place on each checkpoint. Normally these range from 10 to 100 points each. Be aware that high-value checkpoints act like a magnet, and you don't want everyone to go the same way. Ideally a fit team should get roughly the same number of points per hour over most of the course. As a guideline, on hilly country a top team may cover 50 kms in 12 hours, and 80 kms in 24 hours. On flat, open country this could increase to 75 kms and 120 kms respectively. Checkpoints should be in interesting places if possible. They should be clearly visible from all angles at about 20 metres away. Remember, it's a lot harder at night-time.

Other ideas:

Places to look for on the map: Gullies, ridges, peaks, trees, fences, cliffs, forest boundaries, streams, (watercourses), saddles, track bends, stream bends etc.

Rather than look for major gullies , streams, and ridges, look for more subtle side gullies or ridges, as long as the contours exist. It is harder to find a side ridge from a major one, than it is to walk up the minor one from below. The reverse applies to streams; going downstream always keeps you in the major watercourse, whereas going upstream provides plenty of options for mistake. (Hint: if you are doing a rogaine, try to go up ridges and down streams.)

When you choose a suitable site, and visit it, always look for more than one piece of evidence that you are in the right spot. It may be a stream junction, but is it the right distance from an earlier one, or from a known ridge or spur? Are the two or more streams in the right compass bearing? Learn to judge distance by both time, and step-counting. One km = 10 to 15 minutes (more uphill) and also = 500 to 600 double-steps.

A good course should offer a variety of choices for the returning rogainer. There should be enough checkpoints as you approach the HH to plan a zig-zag course, and either take shortcuts or add extras depending on your timing.

Step 3. Site visit. You may have planned a fence junction, but when you get there, the fence is gone. See if there is a convenient local cabbage tree at the head of a gully, or a rock outcrop, or an un-mapped gully. Refine the checkpoint description, but remember that people must be able to find it from the map. If you see a particularly useful feature which isn't marked on the map, use it. Ponds, caves, old sheds, air-strips, a heap of tyres, a wrecked car etc are all useful.

At each site, place a permanent marker wired to a tree or post or rock or bush, and adorn it with some bright flag-tape. Leave a tag saying NZRA and the date.

Write out a control description, which will help people to find it. If there are any dangerous approaches, or preferred ones, take a note. A cabbage tree may sound like a good description, and it sometimes is, but if it is located at a map feature such as a pond or stream junction, use that description instead. It gives more useful information when looking. Do not use cryptic descriptions!

Marked features are traditionally called “THE” rock, whereas un-mapped ones are called “A” gully. Note that Orienteering terms like “Re-entrant” are not used in rogaining, which has its roots in tramping maps. There are water courses, ridges, gullies, and saddles. A gully coloured blue is a watercourse; a gully without blue is a gully. We use “stream” in NZ but internationally a “stream” is a “watercourse” because they are dry most of the time.

Take GPS bearings as a secondary step, but if you have to use GPS to find a checkpoint, it is unfair. The competitors don’t have GPS.

You may also find un-crossable gorges, or areas of impenetrable scrub, and if these are not marked on the map they could cause unfair disadvantage to some route-choices. Note any such discrepancies, including new tracks or vanished fences (especially if they are close to a checkpoint) and request map changes. (Dave - - -). Very steep areas may require a sequence of CPs to guide people away from unsafe areas.

Step 4. At this stage, the map and checkpoint description should be pretty exact. Assign values to checkpoints. We normally have CPs numbered from 10 to 109, meaning you have 10 CPs in each decade value.

While placing highest-value CPS at the top of hills or the edges of the map sounds fair, it isn’t. You can have high values quite close-in. Only the Chris Fornes, who need every CP, will climb 400 metres for 30 points, but the also-rans will look for a beehive on the plains worth 90 points. The whole purpose of assigning values is to encourage people to make different route decisions, so they all start in different directions. If there is an obvious highest-scoring route, everyone plays follow-the-leader.

Grant Hunter has written an excellent guide for checkpoints, called “Pointers for check point placement.doc” which will be put on the website under “Resources”.

Here is an extract:

Field planning
Note areas of impenetrable scrub, dangerous gorges, impassable and scrub-filled streams and mark up the map. These should be marked by bold Xs or OOB on the competition map.

Ideally every CP should be approachable in macroscale (not microscale) from all directions (i.e. from all other CPs). Not always possible or even sensible. Teams should not have to search for them (i.e. not hidden or cryptic). If you navigate to the near proximity, you should be able to see them from a few tens of metres *distant, from the likely approach points. In practice this can be tricky and not always possible. In an open landscape like St James, the navigational challenge is less than in ‘smaller scale’ topography, and check points can sometimes be seen from too far away. It is therefore OK to slightly conceal them e.g. behind a matagouri bush, in a patch of trees/scrub/tall tussock or tucked into a rocky area or in the bottom of a tight gully so that they are visible from a few tens of metres. (May need to advise teams of this at the start.)

*NZ and international rules from 24 champs events, say 40m, but this is not essential for informal events.

Think about how you would attack the CP location (is it fair) and make sure it is reasonably unique. Avoid locations which in all probability would require a grid search to find the CP.

Using the GPS

The GPS is used to log the grid ref only after the CP location has been visually selected and described (almost as an afterthought). This is because the map is the guide for planners as well as participants. A GPS location is just a confirmatory check and for confirming/doublechecking the CP location on the map. While at the site, precisely dot and circle the location on the map, do not rely using on the grid ref in isolation of field features later.

Describing the CP location (clue sheet)

Typical point/site features include rock outcrop, gully, vegetation feature, hilltop, saddle etc. Linear features include streams (e.g. distinctive bend) junctions of track/stream/fence etc

- a tree, a gully etc means the feature is not discernable on the map.
- The tree, the gully etc is discernable on the map (contours, symbols etc)
- If there are multiple similar features in the circle (or even outside if identification is difficult and it is difficult to navigate into the circle) and the feature is an "a" then identify which one. e.g., 'middle', 'east'. Knolls, trees, rock outcrops or even small gullys could fall into this category. Think about how people will identify the exact point without a grid search. Particularly important if the flag is hung low (maybe in matagouri) so that passing it on the wrong side of a bush may mean it is not seen.

Setting up a check point in the field

- Having chosen a site, assess it from different approach points wrt visibility, access etc
- Make sure the micro-location doesn't expose the flags to strong winds as it may be in place for up to 2 weeks before the event. Have in mind how the flag will be hung and note it with the description so the person placing flags is not surprised to find nowhere to hang it.
- Pinpoint the location on the map and visually ensure map location is entirely consistent with the field location. Mark it on the map. Ensure that the circle centre will be at or very close to the actual CP location.
- Describe the check point in brief words as they appear on the 'clue sheet'; also describe it more fully to guide whoever does CP placement and recovery.
- Only then get a GPS grid ref. If you have topo maps on the GPS check visually it is correct. If you don't have maps, do a credibility check that the grid ref sits correctly on the map location.
- Place marker tape for relocation and maybe take location pics to assist the flag placer.
- To label your field work, a good way is to use your initials then a sequential number – avoids problems of different people's work later. e.g. GH01, GH02 etc.

Allocating scores

- Can use 10s up to 100s. I rarely use 10s as they are hardly worth approaching, though can be good to use along some routes to gather a few extra points without diverting too far. Usually use several each of 20s through to 100s. While it can be helpful and fun to assign notional scores during field planning, (e.g. to pick the 100 pointers, or the low scorers) the main scoring effort is best done with the draft map after field work.
- Have some high-scoring CPs relatively close to the start (e.g. no more than half way out on the course) so that 'beginner teams' have the satisfaction of a rewarding score for their efforts.

- Have some high score CPs on the most attractive/appealing features (e.g. look out points, fault traces, nice patches of bush features to help lure teams to the best the area has to offer.

Step 5. Vetting trip. This is your chance to enjoy other people's work. You use the final map and final descriptions, and see if you can find other people's checkpoints. If you can, see if they are fair; they are not hidden (except where unavoidably so, like beside a small waterfall), and they should be findable in the dark. When you do find it, don't just assume that you did so because it is in the right place; check the location from different approach directions. You may have found a marker in a stream bend, but it may be the wrong bend!

If you cannot find a CP, double-check that you are not lost yourself, and if you are still sure, get a GPS confirmation. Place some flag tape or other permanent marker where you think it should be. Preferably include a tag with your name on it. You may also want to look for the CP somewhere similar and quite close, in case the setter got the wrong ridge or gully.

If you find a CP but think it is in the wrong place, leave the marker there but place your own marker at what you think is the correct place.

After the vetting, and possibly while everyone is still there, discuss any discrepancies or problems. It may be that a quick visit from a third person will clarify the problem. In any case, all queries will entail another visit by someone else at some stage.

Step 7. Pretty much like the vetting trip, but you actually place the flags and punches. There is some skill in doing this; many places can be extremely windy. Don't just hang a flag from a post or tree; tie it down so it can't rotate or spin. I often thread the flag over a matagouri bush or other scrub. The punches must be tied securely to something beside the CP, very close. It should be hung so that the punch remains semi-vertical, to reduce the risk of rain flowing down the body and into the punch. Even a drop of water will kill them, often permanently. I recommend placing them in an 80 cm length of black alkathene pipe which is tied or taped (duct tape or electrical tape) to something. This protects them from animals as well, particularly goats, although there is ample evidence that possums eat them too, and cows have been known to.

Remove the permanent marker if it has reflective tape on it, or cover the reflective tape with non-reflective stuff.

The rest is administration. Many hands make light work. Things to think about include map printing, flight plans, plastic bags, catering, toilets, entries and registration, water stops, signage, parking, a safety management plan (Essential if major roads nearby), St.Johns, SAR, power, lights, heat, computers and printers, and navlight. Prize-giving and prizes. Scoring and Results.

Prepare a timeline for the day, including briefing times, map-issuing times, location of Briefing and Finish areas etc.

Step 10. Retrieving check-points. Ask at the prize-giving if anyone can stay the Saturday night, and help the next day. On spare copies of the map, circle the areas for each retriever.